

Sitting down to start something you've been dreading

8 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

You've cleared the time and the task is right in front of you. Your hands won't move, and going hard on yourself at least feels like doing something, like you can still prove **your self-control isn't broken**.

THE GOAL

You're not trying to want this task. You're trying to get through the first few minutes without swapping it for something that feels better right now.

CHECKLIST

You've cleared the time, the task is open in front of you, and something else is starting to look more appealing.

- ☐ Name what you're reaching for instead, in one word (your phone, another tab, or tidying).
- ☐ Put your phone down, close the tab, or step back from whatever pulled you away, before doing anything else with it.
- ☐ Keep whatever pulled you away out of easy reach for this stretch: phone across the room, the other tab closed.
- ☐ Silence notifications and calls for this stretch too, not just the one thing that pulled you away.
- ☐ Look at the actual task in front of you, not the whole project, and name what's dragging (boring, frustrating, or unclear).
- ☐ Pick a stopping point before you start: a time, say twenty minutes, or one small chunk, not 'until it's done.'
- ☐ Write or say one concrete next step: what your hand does first, not why the task matters.
- ☐ If you're waiting to feel ready, skip the wait and **do the first step now** instead.
- ☐ Start the first move: open the file, pick up the tool, dial the number.
- ☐ If the pull comes back, treat it as normal and return to your step; two stalls means naming what you're avoiding, in one sentence.
- ☐ If you catch yourself going over how long you've avoided this, name it once, then look back at the task.
- ☐ Once the step you named is done, pick the next concrete one right away, without checking whether you feel like it.
- ☐ When you reach your stopping point, **write down exactly where you stopped** so the next sit-down isn't a cold start.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Procrastinating doesn't mean you don't want this done. It means you already know it'll cost you for waiting.
- 2 Procrastination's relief is real, but temporary: the stress you dodged can come back, **sometimes worse**.
- 3 Thinking about why a task matters usually doesn't get you moving. Getting into a concrete, how-focused mindset does, even when it's built by thinking through something else first.

What the pull away is actually about

KNOW

Procrastinating doesn't mean you don't want this done. It means you already know it'll cost you for waiting. The field's definition only applies to a task you already intend to finish, not a task you don't care about. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

The relief you feel when you finally look away isn't about this task. In one study, people tricked into believing their mood couldn't be changed stopped putting the task off, suggesting the relief works on mood, not the task itself.

Take away the chance to feel better and there's nothing left for the delay to buy you. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

You don't need to pin down exactly why this particular task feels so bad before you can deal with it. Usually it's a handful of things: boring, frustrating, or lacking clear structure.

Research on procrastination ties the breakdown to a handful of task qualities, rather than a deeper personal cause. [Source 3](#)

Why letting it sit doesn't pay off

KNOW

Procrastination's relief is real, but temporary: the stress you dodged can come back, **sometimes worse**.

Procrastination fixes your mood for a moment, while the task keeps waiting, so the same stress meets you again later. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

Watching videos to escape a task doesn't always feel like a clean break. People who watched cat videos to procrastinate often ended up feeling guilty about that too, on top of the task still waiting.

The guilt is a second bad feeling, stacked on top of what you were already escaping, so what you owe yourself only grows. [Source 2](#)

What gets you moving, and what doesn't

DO

Thinking about why a task matters usually doesn't get you moving. Getting into a concrete, how-focused mindset does, even when it's built by thinking through something else first.

In this study, a concrete how-focused mindset made people act sooner, even when it came from something unrelated to the task. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

People given a concrete, how-focused frame moved on the task sooner than those given an abstract, why-focused frame. It didn't matter how attractive, important, or difficult they'd rated the task themselves.

A concrete framing changes how you're thinking about the task rather than how it feels, so this task isn't the exception. [Source 4](#)

WATCH

Being hard on yourself for not starting isn't linked to less procrastination in any of four separate samples. It's linked to lower self-compassion and higher stress.

Kinder self-talk goes with less procrastination, not more, so easing up isn't the same as letting yourself off the hook. [Source 5](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Waiting until the pressure's really on, right up against the deadline, is what actually gets your best work out of you.

ACTUALLY

In controlled tests, people who scored high on procrastination made more errors and finished less than others under a real time limit. They still rated their own performance as just as good, so feeling like it worked **doesn't mean it did**. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10049005/>
2. <https://www.bbc.com/worklife/article/20200121-why-procrastination-is-about-managing-emotions-not-time>
3. <https://eprints.whiterose.ac.uk/id/eprint/91793/1/Compass%2BPaper%2Brevision%2BFINAL.pdf>
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5. <https://eprints.whiterose.ac.uk/id/eprint/91791/1/ProcrastinationFINAL.pdf>
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Starting when you don't want to at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)